

► Yin and Yang symbol

Adopted by many New Agers, the Yin and Yang in Chinese lore sum up existence. They are in permanent, perfect balance: Yin (the black side) passive; Yang (the white side) active.



Bringing about unity

New Agers are holistic, believing that mind, body, and spirit are one: and so to heal the body it is necessary to heal the mind first. Some even prefer to call their movement Spirituality, or Mind, Body, and Spirit. Yoga and meditation are a means to self-knowledge and the most widely practiced routes to spiritual release. There are numerous forms, including Iyengar, Ashtanga, and Sivananda yoga, and Zen, Transcendental, and Buddhist Vipassana meditation. Both yoga and meditation nurture self-esteem and positive thinking, qualities highly valued among New Age followers. The Law of Attraction—positive thoughts, often spoken out loud as affirmations, reversing and replacing ingrained negative self-beliefs—is helpful to many.

Insight for the future

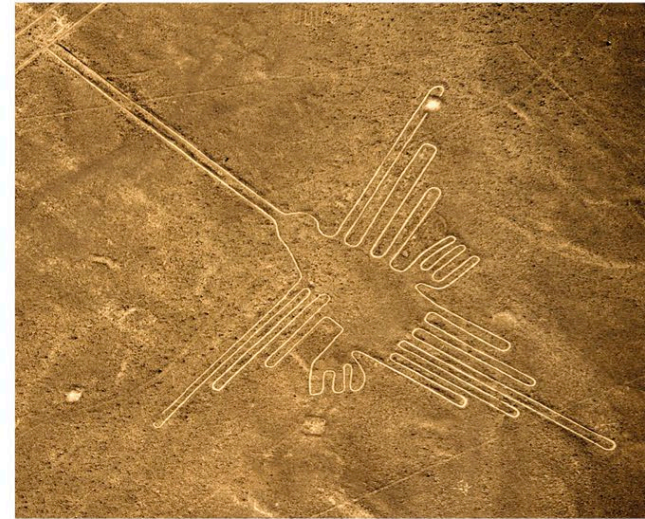
Many New Age practitioners maintain that channelers—certain favored New Agers able to communicate with angels and masters—can act as mediums to contact the dead, and pass on their knowledge and wisdom to the living. Some channelers claim to contact residents of ancient civilizations such as Egypt, South America, or the legendary Atlantis or Mu, and convey their spiritual messages.

Like channeling, astral projection (during which the astral body observes the self and the world from the astral plane) is also thought to put its practitioners in contact with a higher spiritual world. The state of mind that makes such an out-of-

body experience possible is said to be achieved at will, usually through deep and solitary relaxation.

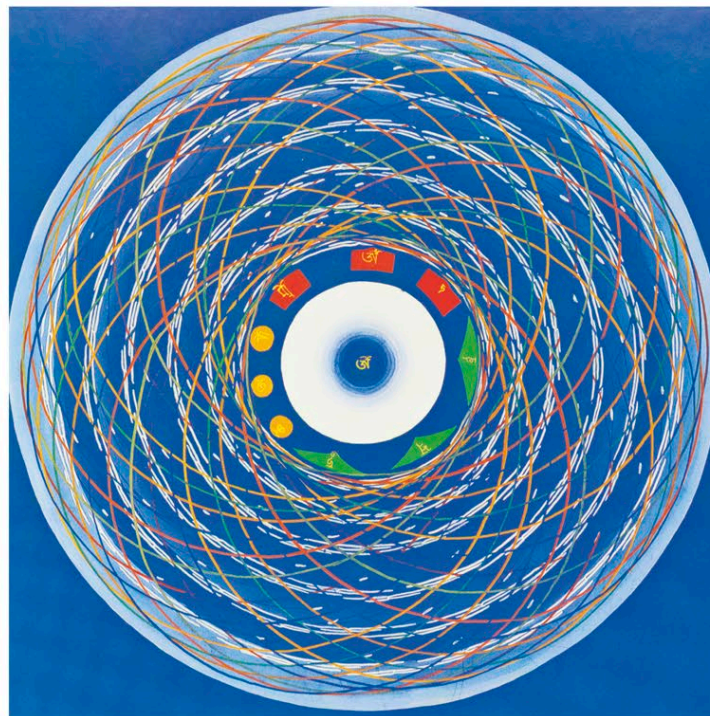
Many New Agers believe in reincarnation, through which the past educates and directs the present. Some followers even assert that alien life forces will prove to be humankind's salvation. Less controversially, many New Age followers simply use visualization to imagine divine creatures, or even just animals, as a path to enlightenment. Others may use psychic readings through I Ching, astrology, crystal balls, or tarot cards (see pp.52–53, 158–161, and 214–219) to predict the future.

None of these practices and beliefs come without critics, many of whom were once New Agers themselves. Some worry that practitioners are less interested in a spiritual vision than in making money from passing fads, at worst endangering the lives of people who buy their wares to treat serious illnesses that need conventional medical treatment. Others complain of vague goals and lack of any coherent belief. For most, however, the myriad beliefs and promise of a purged and purified future are what give the New Age movement its strength.



▲ Nazca lines

New Agers value links to past cultures, such as these giant lines etched onto the sands of Peru, and some followers even try to contact the ancient Nazca people who made them.



► Mandala

Common to Hinduism and Buddhism, a *mandala* illustrates deities. Like many *mandalas* today, this Nepalese example is abstract, conveying the wholeness, unity, and renewal of the cosmos.